



Political ads on Facebook

Lessons that can be learned from the divisive political ads by the Russian troll farms on Facebook. <https://digit.in/jun20-116>



Product placement in movies

The most effective and memorable ways where product placement has been used in movies. <https://digit.in/jun20-117>

FEATURE

holiday, especially booking religious pilgrimages, perhaps? A totally made up example pulled out of thin air, because we don't actually have that data... but if we did, this is the kind of conclusion we could arrive at. Either way, when you're seeing stuff on social media, especially anything promoting products or services, just remember it's paid content.

PROMOTIONAL CONTENT

This one can be hard to spot if not clearly labelled. This is basically what appears to be a review, an article, video or picture (for Instagram) that is positioned as normal everyday content, but is actually a paid promotion. While most people mark these in some way or the other, some do not, and that is concerning. Digit, for example, will add the title sponsored, or call it an advertorial, or promotional feature, etc, and all social media outlets have rules that require marking something as sponsored. However, smaller publishers and influencers are always under pressure to not mark things as sponsored. Some succumb to the pressure in order to earn enough to survive.

BRAND BIAS

We are all biased. We all have likes and dislikes, and more often than not, those are just inexplicable quirks of our nature. There is no way to objectively prove why we prefer one phone brand over the other, but we do, and we all know it. It's the same for hundreds of other things, and usually blind testing proves these biases. This is why we at Digit prefer to keep our opinions objective as far as possible, and we rely on testing methodology that was designed before we tested a product to see how well it has done.

The shameless plug for ourselves aside, we're not really talking about biases that are inbuilt into all humans here, we're talking about affinity of certain brands to certain publishers / content creators. Because so much of this is dependent on human interaction, and some people just get along better than others, there is bound to

be affinities formed based purely on that factor alone. Still, a YouTube creator might have been given his first break by one brand, who gave him or her access to their products, and then over the years the bias seeps in.

Because access to newly launching products are usually given based on importance of the content publisher, and the relationship shared with the brand, the trend of coverage is usually mostly positive for almost all brands these days. It's only when the devices start making their way to everyone else that the balance starts to be found. Of course some products just are awesome, and thus all coverage is generally positive for them.

Sometimes it is easy to spot bias, just by looking at the historical activity of a publisher. Go back to their coverage of earlier devices, if it's a YouTube channel, look at stuff from a year or more ago... see if you can spot a trend for one brand getting much more coverage than others... that's usually a good sign of brand bias that's been built.

LEAKS

Brands have been known to "leak" information to preferred publishers or content creators, which is usually done based on two criteria - how globally significant the content creator is, and also, how loyal a friend they have been to the brand. While there have been a few leaks that are negative, most of them are positive because they're usually controlled. The term 'leak' itself seems wrong now.

Even when a person known to be an insider, gets access to such a leak, they usually sell the story to the highest bidders, because putting up a leaked render of an iPhone 12 would bring you a heck of a lot of traffic, and having that story for an hour or so before everyone else gives you a higher

ranking than others in the news, which in turn results in a lot of traffic.

It's great for the content creator and it's even better for a brand because there is anticipation and excitement being built up about a product that is still far from ready to launch.

TRENDS

As we have seen with political advertising and social media spending, it's not very hard to get a trend going if you're willing to pay for it. Brands also use this to dominate your social feeds as and when they see fit. If everyone seems to be talking about an upcoming phone, you're also going to want to check it out. Why? Fomo! Fear of missing out on a social trend is a crippling addiction, and it's a form of advertising



An example of a divisive political ad on Facebook paid for by Russian troll farms

that's been put to good use by many brands. All of us will still succumb to it, of course, because we're human and can't suddenly start acting like unfeeling robots, but at least you might be able to know what it is you're doing if you're made aware of the problem...

This list is by no means exhaustive, but it covers all the general ways in which brands market their products to you. And we will repeat, it's perfectly fine for things to be marketed to you, it's just important that you know when that is happening. So did you know this stuff was happening all around you? Are there other ways in which marketing is done that you have spotted? Write in and let me know.